EDIGHA FRANCISCA LITERARY SOLUTIONS

Author Book Discoverability Checklist

Twenty two checks across the five elements that decide whether a book is found in Amazon search. Each check names what to look at, why it matters, and what good looks like. Work through them in order, or use the checklist as a review after a book has been published.

EDIGHA FRANCISCA · AUTHOR GROWTH STRATEGIST

01 Keyword fields

5 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 01

All seven backend keyword fields are filled

Amazon provides seven backend keyword slots per book. Many books use only one or two, or leave them at the publisher's default. Each empty slot is a search phrase the book cannot be found for.

What good looks like: *Seven distinct, relevant phrases, none of them repeating the title or subtitle.*

- [ ] CHECK 02

Keywords describe readers, not the book

A keyword is the phrase a reader types when they do not yet know the book exists. It describes the reader's search, not the book's plot. If a keyword only makes sense once the book has been read, it is not a keyword.

What good looks like: *Each keyword is a phrase a stranger would type into search, without knowing the title.*

- [ ] CHECK 03

Keywords include at least three reader intents

Readers search by mood, by trope, by setting, by comparison to another book, and by format. Filling every keyword with the same kind of phrase limits the book to one kind of search.

What good looks like: *At least three of the seven fields cover a different kind of reader search intent.*

- [ ] CHECK 04

No keyword repeats the title or subtitle

Amazon already indexes the title and subtitle. Using the backend fields to repeat them wastes the slots. Each backend field should carry a phrase the title does not already carry.

What good looks like: *Every backend phrase adds a search term the title and subtitle do not cover.*

- [ ] CHECK 05

No prohibited or misleading keywords

Amazon's terms of service exclude certain phrases from metadata: other authors' names, other book titles, and phrases that misrepresent the book. A keyword that violates the terms can cause the listing to be suppressed.

What good looks like: *No keyword uses a name, title or claim the book does not have the right to use.*

02 Categories

4 CHECKS

☐ CHECK 06

Three categories are chosen, not defaulted

Amazon places a book in up to three browse categories. If the categories were not chosen deliberately, they were chosen by the platform on the author's behalf. That is a positioning decision made by a system, not by a strategist.

What good looks like: *Each of the three categories was chosen with a specific browsing reader in mind.*

☐ CHECK 07

At least one category is specific enough to win

A broad category like Fiction buries a new book among hundreds of thousands of titles. A specific category places it among hundreds, where a well presented book can reach the top of the list.

What good looks like: *One category is narrow enough that the book can appear in its top one hundred.*

☐ CHECK 08

At least one category reaches the right browsing reader

A book can win a category and still reach the wrong reader. The category is a statement about who the book is for. If the category signals a genre the book is not, the reader who arrives is the reader who leaves.

What good looks like: *Each category signals the genre and readership the book actually serves.*

☐ CHECK 09

Category placement is reviewed periodically

Amazon's category thresholds shift as sales rank moves. A category that was reachable last quarter may now be out of reach, and one that was out of reach may now be winnable. Category placement is not a decision made once.

What good looks like: *The three categories were reviewed in the last three months.*

03 Cover and title

4 CHECKS

☐ CHECK 10

The cover reads at thumbnail size

A cover is designed at full size and placed at thumbnail size in a list of ten or twenty competing covers. Look at the cover at 160 pixels wide. If the genre is not recognised in one second, the cover is not doing its job.

What good looks like: *The genre is recognised at 160px width without reading the title.*

☐ CHECK 11

The title is legible at small size

A title that is elegant at full size can become illegible at thumbnail size. If the search results show the title as a smudge, the reader must rely on the cover alone to decide whether to click.

What good looks like: *The title is legible in the search results, on a phone screen.*

☐ CHECK 12

The subtitle carries a search phrase

The subtitle is the second largest piece of text on the cover and one of the strongest signals to Amazon's search. If the subtitle is decorative, the search term is not being used.

What good looks like: *The subtitle contains a phrase a reader would type into search.*

☐ CHECK 13

The cover signals the correct genre

Every genre has visual conventions. A psychological thriller looks one way. A cozy mystery looks another. A cover that signals the wrong genre attracts the wrong reader, who leaves as soon as they read the description.

What good looks like: *A reader of this genre would recognise the book as belonging to it.*

04 Description

4 CHECKS

☐ CHECK 14

The first sentence sells the promise, not the plot

The first sentence of the description decides whether the second is read. If it describes a plot event, it is asking the reader to care before they know what the book is for. If it delivers the promise, the reader continues.

What good looks like: *The first sentence reads like a promise, not a summary.*

☐ CHECK 15

The description confirms the cover

The cover makes a promise. The description either confirms it or contradicts it. When the two disagree, the reader feels the disagreement and leaves, often without knowing which of the two they distrusted.

What good looks like: *A reader who saw the cover would recognise the book in the description.*

☐ CHECK 16

The description contains no formatting errors

A description pasted from a manuscript can carry stray HTML, odd line breaks, or lost paragraph breaks. Amazon strips some tags but not all, and the result is a page that looks unmanaged even when the writing is good.

What good looks like: *The description renders cleanly on both desktop and mobile Amazon.*

☐ CHECK 17

The description is the right length

A description that is too short does not give the reader enough to decide. A description that is too long loses them before the end. The length that works depends on the genre, but most descriptions either cut off too early or run on too long.

What good looks like: *The description holds the reader from beginning to end, on a phone.*

05 Author page

5 CHECKS

- [ ] CHECK 18

The author page exists and is claimed

Amazon Author Central is free and takes minutes to set up. A book published without a claimed author page is a book with no face behind it, and a reader who has finished one title has nowhere to go to find a second.

What good looks like: *The author page is live and shows a photograph and biography.*

- [ ] CHECK 19

The biography answers the reader's real question

The reader's real question is what kind of book the author writes. A biography that opens with where the author studied does not answer it. A biography that opens with the kind of book the author writes answers it in one line.

What good looks like: *The first sentence of the biography names the kind of book the author writes.*

- [ ] CHECK 20

Every published title appears on the author page

Amazon sometimes fails to link a title to the author page automatically, especially for books published under a previous pen name, or reissued through a different publisher. A missing title is a reader who cannot find the next book.

What good looks like: *The author page lists every title the author has published.*

- [ ] CHECK 21

Books in a series are grouped as a series

A series that is not grouped tells the reader nothing about the reading order. Book one can appear next to book three, with no indication that book two exists. Grouping is a small change with a large effect on how a series is read.

What good looks like: *A series is visible as a series, with the reading order clear.*

- [ ] CHECK 22

The author page was updated within the last year

A page that has not moved in a year reads as inactive, even when the author is not. The biography, the photograph, and the catalogue order should be reviewed at least once a year, and refreshed when the author publishes something new.

What good looks like: *The author page was reviewed or updated in the last twelve months.*